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“We require a new cadre of business leadership that is audacious enough to tackle uncertainty and chart out a new path for the future”



ROOPA SATISH
MEMBER OF
THE BOARD OF
GOVERNORS, IIM
LUCKNOW

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study preparation, and the organisation is planning a series of Faculty Development Programmes to help them integrate AI more confidently into both teaching and research. So, wherever relevant, courses now include modules on how AI can be used—whether in marketing, finance, analytics, or business strategy. For those who want to go deeper, the school also offers an elective in Year II called AI Concepts and Applications in Business, which gives students a structured understanding of the technology and its implications. But there is a catch.

Says Papiya De, Programme Chairman, MBA and Assistant Professor (Communication) at NMIMS: “We hold a simple belief: AI is not something to be resisted, but something to be used wisely. Some faculty members now ask students to submit not only their project

reports, but also the exact prompts they used while working with AI tools.” This shifts the emphasis from the final output to the thinking that went into it, helping the school promote ethical use of AI.

THE GOVERNANCE MODEL

Growing complexities in the Indian B-school landscape, multiple campuses in the country and abroad, greater focus on new programmes ranging from online MBA to executive education and the need to remain financially viable in a competitive environment will require greater attention of the Board of Governors.

Take the case of IIM Lucknow. The Board, led by N. Chandrasekaran, Chairman of Tata Sons, has in recent months spent a lot of time discussing emerging issues that will impact the future of B-schools and to develop strategies to respond to them.

Says Roopa Satish, Member of the Board of Governors, IIM Lucknow, and a 1992 batch alumna: “Traditionally, educational institutions in India have tended to be more academically focused, with industry adaptation taking place at a more gradual pace. The greatest challenge facing Indian B-schools today is: How do we remain relevant in an era defined by digital transformation and pervasive technology? This was deliberated at length in a recent Board meeting.”

Boards today get into the minutiae of the B-school’s activities. For example, the role that AI will play in businesses and B-schools are aspects that have occupied the attention of many boards.

Adds Satish, “We have to build this long-term thinking capability in our students.” IIM-L has decided to strengthen its collaboration with Indian Institutes of Technology. “We are in advanced talks with IIT Kanpur,” she says.

While the above three are among the most important aspects that will define the future of Indian B-schools, it is by no means a complete list. Globalisation of Indian B-schools and foreign ones setting up in the country are also factors.

What would help, perhaps, is if all B-schools were allowed to tackle these challenges in ways that they feel are the best. On this front, government-backed schools face bigger hurdles, especially the premier IIMs. Despite the Union Cabinet clearing the way for the IIM Bill 2022 that granted complete autonomy to these institutions, there have been reports that there is a gap between intent and execution.

It is time to address some of these issues to ensure that Indian B-schools are ready to adapt to a rapidly changing world. **BT**